News Norms

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Abstract

Collective choices such as democratic decision-making run on attention, but attention to public affairs is often socially valuable and privately costly. This paper studies news norms, social expectations that "a good citizen stays informed", and shows how they raise demand for political information through social image. In a pre-registered experiment, making political knowledge observable to peers increases willingness to pay for political news by about 21%. The effect is larger when participants believe their audience cares about being informed and can evaluate knowledge. Cross-national survey evidence shows that news norms are widely perceived and display systematic socioeconomic gradients. Together, the results identify a mechanism through which social environments can increase political information acquisition and contribute to persistent inequalities in political knowledge and political voice.

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"He'd tell us that in a democracy, keeping abreast of current events was a citizen's most important duty and that you could never start too early to be informed about the news of the day."
The Plot Against America – Roth (2004)

Many collective decisions - elections, referenda, jury decisions, and workplace or committee choices - rely on members acquiring costly information. Yet the private return to becoming informed is often small relative to the social return: an informed vote or voice can affect outcomes for many, but the cost of paying attention is borne individually. This wedge creates a classic underinvestment problem - an externality - in attention and political knowledge.

Democratic politics is a canonical case. Individual citizens have arguably little material incentive to follow public affairs because any one vote is unlikely to be pivotal (Prat and Strömberg, 2013), even though informed participation can matter greatly for collective outcomes. Moreover, information that is socially useful for accountability and policy choice is not necessarily privately rewarding or entertaining to consume. The result is a potentially persistent gap between the social value of (political) knowledge and individuals' private incentives to acquire it.

This paper argues that an important and underexplored response to this wedge is the emergence of *political information norms*, which I refer to as *news norms*, shared expectations that "a good citizen stays informed." Despite extensive work on media markets and on social incentives shaping what people express, we know much less about whether and when social enforcement increases individuals' *demand* for political information. This paper therefore asks three questions: How prevalent are news norms across contexts and groups? Do they causally increase information acquisition when knowledge becomes socially observable? And how does the strength of these social incentives depend on norm strengths, the perceived audience - what individuals believe others expect and can evaluate?

Such norms matter because they are enforced socially. When being informed is valued, individuals anticipate social evaluation, and information acquisition becomes a way to manage one's image - signaling traits such as competence, civic-mindedness, or sophistication. By embedding social rewards and sanctions into an otherwise private choice, news norms can raise information demand. At the same time, they may distort learning, by shaping what is worth knowing and communicating, and generate inequality when norm strength and enforcement differ across social groups.

I provide causal evidence that social exposure increases demand for political news. In a pre-

registered laboratory experiment, participants choose between money and access to short news articles that help answer factual questions about salient international conflicts. Making answers publicly observable to peers increases willingness to acquire the articles by about 21%. A central implication of the mechanism is that social exposure should matter most when the relevant audience is perceived as normatively demanding and able to evaluate political knowledge. I test this prediction directly by measuring beliefs about the audience and summarizing them in an audience "norms and evaluative capacity" index. In a structural interpretation of participants' choices, the public-observability effect is sharply amplified by this index: when the perceived audience is indifferent or unable to judge, social-image incentives are small; when the perceived audience is demanding and evaluative, social-image incentives become quantitatively important.

These results motivate a simple inequality perspective. If norm environments systematically differ across socioeconomic groups, then otherwise similar individuals face different social returns to becoming informed, generating persistent gaps in political knowledge and political voice. By the same logic, heterogeneous news norms can translate into unequal information acquisition and, in turn, unequal influence over collective decisions.

Finally, I analyze cross-national survey evidence showing that news norms are widely perceived and vary systematically across groups. Across 19 countries, large majorities report that following politics and international affairs is important for being a good member of society (Pew, 2022), and U.S. survey evidence suggests these beliefs are longstanding (GSS, 1984). Using data from 64 countries (World Values Survey), I document patterns consistent with social interaction being associated with greater information acquisition. Using Pew data, I show that socioeconomic correlates of political knowledge, such as education and income, also predict stronger perceived importance of staying informed (Pew, 2022), consistent with the idea that norm inequality can contribute to information inequality. These are the same correlates that predict higher news knowledge in the U.S. (Angelucci and Prat, 2024).

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 1 presents a framework in which individuals acquire news for both private value and social-image value and derives testable predictions. Sections 2 and 3 describe the experimental design and present causal evidence that social observability increases demand for political information. Section 4 provides a structural interpretation that quantifies how perceived audience norms and evaluative capacity amplify social-image incentives. Section 5 presents cross-national survey evidence on the prevalence of news norms and their socioeconomic gradients. Section 6 concludes.

Literature This paper contributes to several strands of research. First, it complements a growing literature on how social image concerns shape the *supply* of political information - what individuals choose to express, share, or suppress (e.g., Bursztyn et al., 2020; Braghieri, 2021; Bursztyn et al., 2023; Guriev et al., 2023; Huang and Ho, 2023) - by focusing on the *demand* side: how image concerns influence whether individuals acquire political information in the first place, a particularly salient question in high-choice media environments where attention is the primary bottleneck to learning (e.g., Matějka and Tabellini, 2021).

Second, it relates to Marshall (2019), who studies sophistication signaling and political knowledge in Mexican elections. Relative to this work, I implement a pre-registered experiment that directly measures demand for political information and I quantify how treatment effects vary with perceived audience properties. Third, the paper contributes to research on political learning and news consumption (e.g., Mullainathan and Shleifer, 2005; Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2006) and to recent experimental work on information demand (e.g., Chopra et al., 2022; Bursztyn et al., 2023; Chopra et al., 2023; Levy et al., 2026), responding to calls to examine social motives in information acquisition (Capozza et al., 2022). Alongside Moehring and Molina (2023), it provides evidence that social incentives can be an important determinant of political information demand, with implications for information inequality and democratic inclusion.

1 Framework: Political information norms

1.1 Setup

Consider an individual i and a political topic j. In each decision situation l, individual i chooses whether to acquire information about topic j. Let $d_{ijl} \in \{0, 1\}$ denote this choice, where $d_{ijl} = 1$ means that i acquires information (reads an article, follows a news story) and $d_{ijl} = 0$ means that she does not. Acquiring information entails a monetary or opportunity cost $p_l \geq 0$.

Information acquisition may be socially evaluated by others. Let $g \in \mathcal{G}$ index a relevant audience or reference group (friends, classmates, colleagues, online followers). With probability $\nu_{ig} \in [0, 1]$, individual i expects to be socially exposed to audience g in a way that could reveal whether she is informed about topic j (for instance, through discussion or social media interaction). For most of the analysis it is convenient to focus on a single salient audience, but keeping g explicit helps to clarify the underlying objects.

The audience cares about some latent type $\theta_i \in \{0, 1\}$ that is socially valued in this setting, such

as being an informed and civic (or interested) person. If exposure occurs, the audience observes signals about i's knowledge (e.g., how she answers questions or participates in a conversation) and updates its belief that $\theta_i = 1$. Let

$$\mu_{gj}(d; e_{gj}) \equiv \Pr(\theta_i = 1 \mid d, e_{gj})$$

denote audience g's posterior belief, where e_{gj} captures the audience's evaluative capacity for topic j: higher e_{gj} means that the audience can better infer θ_i from d.

Different audiences may care more or less about information and the types who get informed. Let $w_{gj} \geq 0$ denote the strength of political information norms in audience g for topic j - how much the audience values being informed about this topic. For transparency, w_{gj} captures the normative component (duty, care), while e_{gj} captures evaluative capacity (ability to distinguish correct from incorrect answers).

In practice, I will not separately identify w_{gj} and e_{gj}. Instead, I work with a reduced-form "audience norms and evaluative capacity" index

$$m_{gj} = f(w_{gj}, e_{gj}),$$

which summarizes how strongly the audience facing i (i) cares about being informed and (ii) can evaluate knowledge about topic j.

To connect to the experiment, let $Public_i \in \{0, 1\}$ indicate whether i's answers about topic j will be publicly observable (the Public condition, $Public_i = 1$) or remain confidential (the Private condition, $Public_i = 0$). When $Public_i = 0$, the audience cannot condition on d_{ijl}.

1.2 Preferences and information demand

Let $b_{ij}(\theta_i)$ denote the private (non-social) gross benefit from being informed about topic j (e.g., usefulness for voting, intrinsic interest). Let $\alpha > 0$ be the marginal utility of money, so that the private cost of acquiring information in scenario l is αp_l.

In addition, individual i derives utility from how the audience perceives her type. Let $\lambda \geq 0$ capture the sensitivity of utility to social-image concerns. For a given audience g, the image benefit from acquiring information rather than not can be written as

$$\nu_{ig} \lambda \, w_{gj} \big[\mu_{gj}(1; e_{gj}) - \mu_{gj}(0; e_{gj})\big],$$

Absorbing w_{gj} and e_{gj} into the index m_{gj} yields a reduced-form image payoff proportional to $\lambda\, m_{gj}$ whenever decisions are observable to g.

For each scenario (i, j, l), the latent utility difference between choosing the article and choosing the money can therefore be written as

$$\Delta U_{ijl} = b_j - \alpha p_l + \lambda \cdot Public_i \cdot m_{gj} + \xi_{ijl}, \tag{1}$$

where $\nu_{ig}(Public) - \nu_{ig}(private) = 1$, b_j is the topic-specific private value of the article, $\alpha > 0$ is the marginal utility of money, λ measures the strength of social-image motives, m_{gj} is the audience norms and evaluative capacity index, and ξ_{ijl} is an unobserved component capturing all remaining determinants of the choice in scenario (i, j, l) including individual-specific heterogeneity in b. When $Public_i = 0$, the image term is zero; when $Public_i = 1$, the social payoff from being informed increases in the audience norms and evaluative capacity index m_{gj}.

The individual chooses $d_{ijl} = 1$ if and only if $\Delta U_{ijl} \geq 0$. This yields the following qualitative predictions:

1. **Social exposure increases information demand.** Holding p_l and m_{gj} fixed, moving from Private to Public ($Public_i : 0 \to 1$) increases ΔU_{ijl} by λm_{gj}, so the probability of acquiring information is higher when choices are observable.

2. **Audience norms and evaluative capacity amplify social incentives.** The marginal effect of $Public$ on information acquisition is proportional to m_{gj}. When m_{gj} is low - audiences are perceived as indifferent or unable to judge - $Public$ has little effect. When m_{gj} is high, $Public$ substantially raises the value of being informed.

3. **Norm heterogeneity induces information inequality.** Suppose there are two groups $g \in \{A, B\}$ that differ only in their audience index m_g, with $m_A > m_B$. Then, for any given price p_l, group A is more likely to acquire information than group B when choices are publicly observable ($Public_i = 1$). Systematic differences in m_g across socioeconomic groups can therefore translate into persistent inequalities in news knowledge.

In the empirical sections, I take this reduced-form representation seriously. The structural logit model used in Section 4 assumes that the conditional probability of choosing the article is a logistic function of the utility difference in (1) and estimates the parameters α and λ from observed MPL choices, using the same index m_{gj} constructed from beliefs about duty, care, and correctness.

2 Experiment

Identifying the effects of social norms through social image concerns in observational data is difficult, and therefore, I conduct a laboratory experiment with students at Bocconi University in Milan, Italy. The experiment is designed to test (i) the effects of social image concerns on political information acquisition (prediction 1) and (ii) how these effects depend on the expected audience and the audience's actions (prediction 2). To test (i), I randomly vary the exposure of students' political knowledge to an audience. Prediction 1 states that anticipated exposure increases information acquisition. To collect evidence of (ii), I randomly vary the information that the audience has obtained. My framework suggests that the effect of social image concerns depends on how the audience's information shapes students' beliefs about how much the audience cares and knows about the topic. Thus, I measure how these beliefs about the audience's engagement vary with beliefs about the audience's information and how these belief changes mediate the effects of social image concerns. In the following subsections, I discuss details of the experimental setting, the intervention, my outcome measures, and the robustness of my setup.

2.1 Experimental Design

Setting I implement a laboratory experiment at the Bocconi Laboratory (BELSS) at the end of May 2024. Students were recruited through the systems of the BELSS laboratory and a neutral email that invited them to a study on "decision-making". I ran 28 sessions between May 27th and May 31st, 2024, and September 5th and September 11th with 346 participating students. The entire experiment was conducted in English. While courses at Bocconi are commonly offered in English, and many degree programs are entirely conducted in English, English skills are heterogeneous. To prevent comprehension issues, I filter the pool of students for students who speak English on an "Advanced" or "Native" level and understand English "perfectly" or on an "advanced" level.

In addition to the active students, I recruited between three and four students per session as an audience whose purpose I explain below.[1]

The topics considered in the experiment are the Israel-Hamas conflict and the Russia-Ukraine conflict. Since this project is also a test of the *potential* of social image concerns to affect political

[1] Together with the lab manager, we ensured that at least two audience members were present to truthfully mention a "group of students" to the treated (see below). When audience members were missing, we recruited backups from a pool of master's and PhD students. For PhD students, we did not recruit anyone heavily involved in teaching to avoid students recognizing teaching assistants. None of the participating PhD students reported contact with their present or former students.

information acquisition, I'm interested in using topics for which these may be particularly relevant. In May 2024, I ran a small online survey with 61 Bocconi students to get an approximate measure of social image concerns for different topics. The topics include climate change, national elections, international conflicts, public health, and unpolitical topics (movies and football). The hypothetical median willingness to pay (WTP) for information before one is confronted with questions from other students is the highest for the conflicts about Russia and Ukraine and Israel and Hamas (3 and 4€ respectively). Summary results of this online pilot are available upon request. Beyond the relatively high WTP in the pilot, the two conflicts have been persistently salient (e.g., they score high on Google trends in Italy and elsewhere and have been the top stories in the world section of the NYT for some time). Thus, if social expectations are stronger for more salient topics, I expect stronger effects for these topics, and thus, importantly, given the sample restrictions, greater statistical power. In addition, these topics are relatively similar which may simplify the measurement of potential interaction effects.

I also use information from the pilot to determine an approximately plausible price range and steps for the multiple price list.[2]

Intervention Students are randomly assigned to one of two treatment conditions: *Public* or Private. Each seat in the laboratory has one of the two survey versions and students are randomly allocated to a seat upon arrival. [3]

At the beginning of the study, students in both conditions are informed that they will be asked to write answers to factual questions about the Israel-Hamas conflict *and* the Russia-Ukraine conflict during the experiment. In addition, students in *Public* are informed that they will be asked to read aloud their answers to a group of students outside the laboratory at the end of the experiment.[4]

At the end of this study, you will read out your answers to a group of students outside the laboratory. *In the following, we will refer to this group as the "audience."*

[2] Also, I elicit students' trust in news sources and find that trust in the New York Times is particularly high. Thus, I use NYT articles as information sources. However, this is secondary for WTP because students are not informed about the sources before their choices. That said, the choice of sources may matter for the secondary outcomes described below.

[3] A version of the *Public* survey can be found here: https://bocconi.eu.qualtrics.com/jfe/preview/previewId/3c5ba610-ebf1-4b9e-8140-f50207db55de/SV_8H23V0ivd9PSfgG?Q_CHL=preview&Q_SurveyVersionID=current and a version of the *Private* survey is available here: https://bocconi.eu.qualtrics.com/jfe/preview/previewId/c2c23a41-5dc8-4978-ab38-8345429c6d89/SV_bOaxmxAi07SHNXM?Q_CHL=preview&Q_SurveyVersionID=current.

[4] This aspect of the design draws from Bénabou et al. (2023).

In contrast, students in *Private* are informed that their answers will be shared anonymously with a group of students and that their identity will remain confidential.

After this study, your answers are sent anonymously to a group of students. *In the following, we will refer to this group as the "audience." The audience will not know your identity. The audience will not be able to link your answers to you.*

Also, students are informed that the audience has obtained information either about the Israel-Hamas or Russia-Ukraine conflict. This served to test for interactions in information acquisition induced by social image concerns. The topic the audience is informed about is randomly varied at the session level.

Outcomes During the experiment, subjects are asked for their willingness to pay (WTP) for short articles that can help answer the questions about the Israel-Hamas or the Russia-Ukraine conflict respectively. To measure WTP, students choose from a multiple price list with 10 scenarios for each article out of which one scenario is randomly drawn and the choice in that scenario is implemented. Each scenario corresponds to one price and the prices are 0.00€, 0.25€, 0.50€, 1.00€, 2.00€, 3.00€, 4.00€, 5.00€, 7.50€, 10.00€.

After making their choices, subjects either receive the articles or wait one minute for each article they do not receive. This corresponds approximately to the time it takes to read each article and eliminates the perceived value of time from subjects' decision-making to obtain arguably cleaner and less noisy valuations of the information.[5]

I pre-registered as secondary outcomes the time students take to read the articles, the time they take to answer the questions, the length of their answers, and whether their answers are correct. The hypotheses are that image concerns increase any of the above. The time students take to read complements WTP as a measure of information acquisition and the measures are proxies of information transmission.

Robustness and Validity The robustness of my experimental design is bolstered by several decisions aimed at mitigating biases and ensuring the validity of my findings. First, my design

[5]To obtain reading time estimates for the articles, I use https://thereadtime.com/.

acknowledges that students may have altruistic motives to acquire information such as the desire to help others or an interest in persuading others. To account for this, information is also shared with others in the (active) control condition *Private*. Thus, social incentives arising from communication other than image concerns should also affect outcomes in the private condition. If information about details of the experiment spills over to later sessions, I expect that particularly image-sensitive individuals either do not sign up or do not show up. In this case, attrition lowers treatment effects which makes my estimates of effect sizes a lower bound. I try to avoid this issue by appealing to students not to share information about the experimental design with other students. The design of the appeal is inspired by Alesina et al. (2023). This also aims to prevent information about articles or questions spilling over from one session to another which, again, would reduce WTP and possibly other outcomes. As an additional measure, I tell students (truthfully) that not all students get the same articles and questions. An important advantage of WTP as an outcome measure in contrast to measures of political knowledge is that it gives a lower bound of effects in the presence of cheating (e.g., using phones). Finally, the design of the instructions is equivalent apart from the treatment mitigating experimenter demand bias. If anything, I'd expect stronger demand or desirability bias with respect vis a vis the experimenter in *Private* since students are asked to share information anonymously, which may be considered a greater signal of altruism (Bénabou and Tirole, 2006) and exposure to an audience may cause backlashes in terms of demand effects.

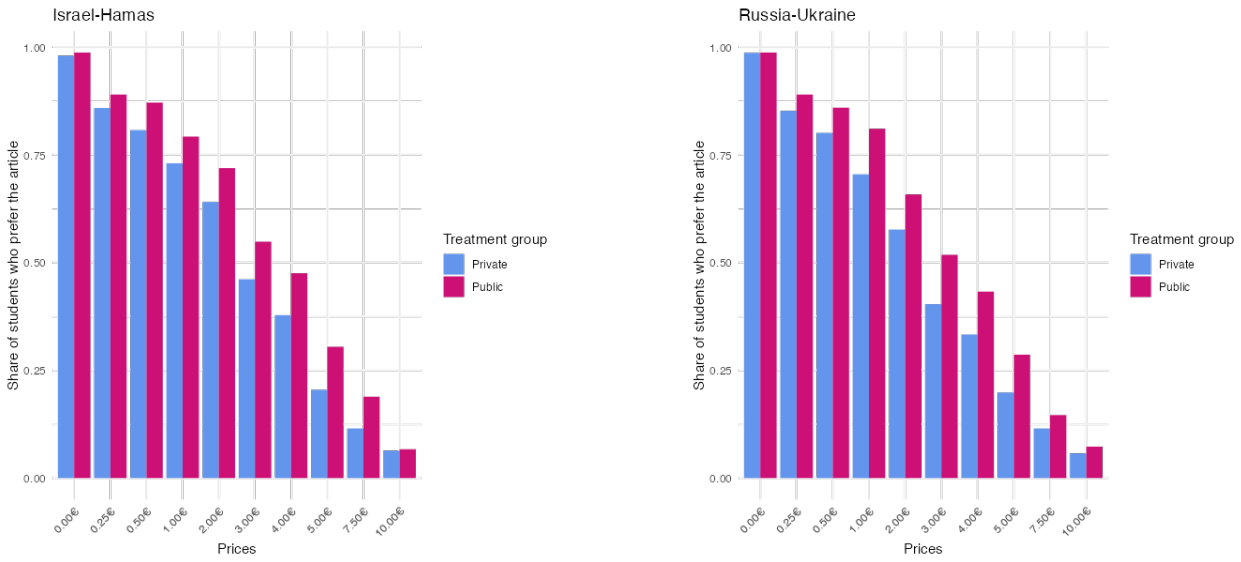
While the laboratory setting comes with restrictions in terms of external validity, it offers multiple advantages that make it an appealing setting for my study. First, it allows (almost) perfect control and measurement of students' information acquisition. Other studies came up with creative ways to control the information environment in online settings (e.g., Bursztyn et al. (2023)) but do not offer the same degree of control.[6] Second, the lab experiment allows me to vary the audience and its features (or actions), a strength I use to approximate interaction effects as discussed in the following sections. An additional advantage of my setting, unrelated to the laboratory, is the sample of students who are in their political "impressionable years" (e.g., Krosnick and Alwin (1989)). What they learn, therefore, affects their political attitudes much stronger than it does for people of other ages. Thus, understanding the drivers of information decisions in my sample is particularly

[6]Non-compliance or "cheating" (i.e., consulting help including other information sources) is usually hard to measure as participants have weakly negative incentives for disclosure. Marshall (2019) ingeniously uses list experiments to approximate the share of students who discuss questions with others as 35%. This finding furthers the need for controlled information environments.

relevant beyond this specific context.

3 Results

As preregistered, I focus on students who make consistent choices in the multiple price lists. Figure 1a shows that students assigned to *Public* (treated) are more likely to choose either article (Israel-Hamas and Russia-Ukraine) at any given price. This is reflected in the WTP for news articles which is substantially higher for the treated. The mean total WTP for the two articles is 7.95 Euro in *Public* and 6.59 Euro in *Private*. Thus, the treated forgo about 21% more money to obtain the two articles than the control group. The two topics contribute roughly equivalently to this increase. The mean WTP for the Israel-Hamas article is 21% higher in the treated group. A similar picture holds for the Russia-Ukraine article where WTP in the treated group is 21% higher.[7]



(a) Share of chosen articles by treatment group and price (IH)

(b) Share of chosen articles by treatment group and price (RU)

Figure 1: Comparison of article preferences by treatment group and price

Again, as preregistered, I use two-sided t-tests which reject equality of mean total WTP (p-

[7] I construct WTP as the midpoint between the highest price at which students prefer the article and the lowest price at which students prefer the money. This approach is commonly applied (Jack et al., 2022) in different settings of economic research (Andersen et al., 2006; Allcott and Kessler, 2019; Cullen and Perez-Truglia, 2022). Like Cullen and Perez-Truglia (2022), I use the lower bound for the highest price (10 Euro). Alternative measures of WTP include the switching point, thus, the lowest price at which students prefer the money or the highest price at which they prefer the article. The former gives slightly larger effect sizes and the latter gives slightly smaller effect sizes than the midpoint approach. Qualitatively, all measures produce equivalent results. Results are available upon request.

value = 0.034) and WTP for the articles separately (p-values = 0.035 and 0.046). However, the t-tests assume normally distributed variables and Shapiro tests reject the normality of WTP (p-value = 0.00). Thus, I use two-sided Wilcoxon tests which reject equality of total WTP between treatment groups (p-value = 0.036). Similarly, equality of WTP for the Israel-Hamas (p-value = 0.042) and the Russia-Ukraine article (p-value = 0.032) are rejected. P-values for one-sided tests are mechanically lower. I provide test results in the appendix.

I conclude that assignment to *Public*, and thus, social image concerns increase WTP. Next, I substantiate this finding with a more structured analysis and investigate potential interactions in information acquisition.

3.1 Empirical Strategy

The main analysis consists of testing if (i) social image concerns induce political information acquisition or news demand and if (ii) social image concerns induce interactions in political information acquisition/news demand. As pre-registered, I perform the analyses with different subsets of the data. First, I run the analyses with all students who make consistent choices in the MPL. Second, I run the analysis with students who participated in the final version of the experiment, which means I exclude eight students who completed a test run with slightly different survey instructions. I also run the analysis with students who are assumed to comprehend the instructions well. Following my pre-registration, I only include students who (i) passed a minor comprehension check at the end of the instructions and (ii) indicated that they found the instructions at least moderately comprehensible. Finally, I consider the intersection of these two sets. I use all these sets to run regressions of the following form:

$$WTP_{il} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Public_i + \beta_2 High_{il} + \beta_3 Public_{il} \text{x} High_{il} + \mu_l + \varepsilon_{il}$$

where individual i chooses her WTP_{il} for an article on topic l. Each i is associated with session k and a unique social image treatment status $\in \{Public, Private\}$, and each i, l combination determines a unique audience-information status $\in \{High, Low\}$. The coefficients of interest are β_1 and β_3. β_1 captures the effect of social image concerns on WTP and β_3 captures interaction effects. I control for topic- and session fixed effects μ_{lk}.[8] Aligned with the clustering of the main

[8]The number of students per session varied due to the volatility of sign-ups. The session fixed effects aim to eliminate this source of noise to increase precision. Results are very similar without session fixed effects and available

treatment, I cluster standard errors on the individual level. Results are summarized in table 1.

Table 1: Regression Results with Session FE

	Dependent variable:			
	WTP			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Treat	0.646**	0.717**	1.095***	1.177***
	(0.322)	(0.326)	(0.347)	(0.350)
High	0.029	0.021	0.083	0.075
	(0.120)	(0.120)	(0.133)	(0.132)
Treat:High	0.112	0.121	0.051	0.073
	(0.166)	(0.166)	(0.189)	(0.189)
Topic FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Clustered SE	ID	ID	ID	ID
Observations	640	626	536	524
R^2	0.116	0.121	0.173	0.181
Adjusted R^2	0.071	0.076	0.122	0.131
Note:				*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

The results indicate that, after accounting for interactions, social image concerns increase WTP by 0.65€ to 1.18€ per article. These results underpin that social image concerns induce political information acquisition. The directional effect of the interactions in information acquisition through social image concerns (β_3) and beyond (β_2) hint towards an amplifying interaction. However, statistical power is insufficient to establish this observation. I discuss these results further in the next part of this section. Before, I turn to alternative, pre-registered outcome measures.

3.2 Secondary Analysis

Learning To learn, students need to acquire the article and pay attention to it. The prior section established the first part of the link: Students in *Public* are willing to forgo more money than students in *Private* which shows that social image concerns induce students to acquire the information. Second, students need to learn from the information. To test this, I estimate a linear probability model in which I test the relationship between obtaining the article and answering questions

upon request.

correctly.[9] I control for set and session fixed effects and find that receiving the article about the Israel-Hamas conflict (Russia-Ukraine conflict) increases the probability of answering the question about the Israel-Hamas conflict (Russia-Ukraine conflict) by about 51 percentage points (34 percentage points). Leveraging that obtaining the article conditional on WTP is random, I estimate a further specification in which I control for WTP to account for potential selection into obtaining the article and find that the results are robust when accounting for possible endogeneity.[10] Table 2 summarizes results.

Table 2: Regression Results with Robust Standard Errors

	Dependent variable:			
	Correct answer IH		Correct answer RU	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
IH-Article	0.514***	0.593***		
	(0.059)	(0.068)		
RU-Article			0.337***	0.307***
			(0.079)	(0.111)
Set FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
WTP FE		Yes		Yes
Robust SE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	320	320	320	320
R^2	0.205	0.220	0.129	0.170
Adjusted R^2	0.128	0.118	0.045	0.061
Note:				*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

A more direct test of learning effects through regressing correct answers on treatment status lacks power (see column 1 in table 3), presumably because the first stage is weak. A one Euro increase in WTP increases the probability of receiving the article significantly but only by about 5 percentage points, as shown in columns 1 and 2 of table 11.[11] Consequently, the treated are only marginally more likely to receive the article (columns 3 and 4 of table 11) and, given that the mapping from receiving the article into answering correctly introduces additional noise (see table

[9] I classify answers as correct if they at least partially answer the question and do not contain false information.

[10] WTP is discrete because I construct it from an MPL as discussed above. I control for WTP flexibly by using a factor variable. Importantly, this also controls for WTP if its relationship with the correct answer probability is not linear.

[11] This follows by construction from the randomization of scenarios in the MPL.

2), the treated are roughly 5 percentage points more likely to answer correctly, but differences are not statistically significant(column 1 in table 3).

Table 3: Regression Results

	Dependent variable:		
	Correct answer	Answering time (seconds)	Answer length (characters)
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Treat	0.051	1.394	0.690
	(0.043)	(2.369)	(4.538)
Topic X Set FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Clustered SE	ID	ID	ID
Observations	640	640	640
R^2	0.059	0.128	0.090
Adjusted R^2	0.008	0.080	0.040
Note:			*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

I conclude that, given my sample size, I am not sufficiently powered to establish the link between treatment status and correct answers directly. However, summarizing the above, I find evidence that the treatment induces participants to obtain information and that information is effectively used to answer questions correctly, which I interpret as learning. In sum, my preferred interpretation suggests that social image concerns positively affect political learning in this experiment.

Additional outcomes I do not find significant differences between treatment groups concerning the time students take to read the article (see table 12) or the time they take to answer the questions (see table 3). I suggest this is because the articles are relatively short and the questions require only brief answers.[12]

Heterogeneity analysis As mentioned above, I do not detect statistically significant interactions in information acquisition.

I perform pre-registered manipulation checks to understand the (seeming absence of) interactions. I hypothesized that an audience who has obtained information about a given topic is perceived as more informed or caring about the topic, more likely to perceive it as a civic duty to

[12]Equivalently, I do not find differences in the length of the answers. Note that complete and correct answers don't need to be long (also table 3).

be informed about the topic, and more able to discriminate between correct and incorrect statements about the topic. Thus, I test the effect of the within-treatment on those beliefs. I find significant positive effects on students' beliefs about the audience's ability to discriminate between correct and incorrect statements but not on beliefs about how much the audience can learn from the article, cares, or perceives it as a civic duty to be informed about a given topic (table 13).

I interpret that students assume that the audience has obtained information about the topic or subject of interest in the experiment but do not believe that the audience has actively pursued that information or that it is generally better informed. This is aligned with the following two remarks about my treatment. First, the treatment may be subtle, and the information obtained by the audience may not be salient to students throughout the experimental procedure. Second, the wording of the treatment is "Note that the audience has obtained information about the Israel-Hamas [Russia-Ukraine] conflict", which may suggest that the audience obtained the information passively. Assuming a passive role in information acquisition prohibits students from inferring the audiences' types from their information possession. I made the treatment design decisions so as not to deceive students. Alternative designs may shed light on interactions in information acquisition induced by social incentives.

As pre-registered, I also test directly for the relationship between these beliefs and WTP. While none of the relationships is significant at the 5%-level, I make two observations. First, all relationships are positive (see table 14). Second, all beliefs apart from those in the audience's ability to learn from the article interact positively with the treatment (see table 15). Thus, it appears that beliefs in the audience's ability to discriminate between correct and incorrect statements, how much it cares, and whether it perceives being informed as a civic duty, increases information acquisition in the presence of social image concerns. On the contrary, a perception of the audience's ability to learn from the article may rather increase information acquisition through altruism or other concerns that do not relate to social image concerns. While it is too early to conclude, these differential effects suggest that social image concerns, anticipated interaction, and the social environment may induce more complex incentives for (political) information acquisition. Importantly, the directions of these effects are consistent with prediction 2. Future research with larger samples or alternative treatment designs may shed further light on these mechanisms.

Text analysis I ask participants two open-ended questions to illuminate mechanisms in a pre-registered text analysis. First, I ask them "What factors played a role in your choice between

the articles and the monetary compensation?" I check manually for mentions of different factors including social image concerns, prior knowledge, and information sharing.[13] I find explanations referring to the money amounts, prior knowledge, audience and social pressure, the audience's information set, expectations about the article (quality, bias, length), news/information avoidance, and morals or perceptions of duty among others. I also ask students "How would the audience of students describe someone who is knowledgeable about political news in comparison to someone who is uninformed?". Overall, students expect that the audience perceives someone informed more positively. Among others, I find mentions related to knowledge, education, social responsibility, altruism, maturity, reliability, ignorance, egoism, and intelligence.

3.3 Further Discussion

The experiment provides clean evidence that social image concerns increase demand for political information and offers suggestive support for effects on learning and interaction dynamics. A noteworthy observation is that students in the *Private* condition are, on average, willing to forgo €6.59 for access to information, even though articles on the Israel-Hamas and Russia-Ukraine conflicts are freely available.[14] While this magnitude may appear high, several plausible explanations exist. Importantly, none of them threaten the internal validity of the treatment effect, as they apply equally across conditions.

First, features of the multiple price list (MPL) may have influenced responses - for example, through a central tendency bias or framing effects. While this could inflate WTP levels overall, it would not confound between-group comparisons.

Second, curiosity may play a role. The experimental setting, combined with extended interaction and topic salience, may induce "suspense" or elevate perceived relevance, thereby increasing information demand (see Ely et al., 2015; Golman and Loewenstein, 2018). If so, this form of experimental curiosity may arise in other lab settings as well. Future designs should consider including an active control to account for such effects.

Third, even in the *Private* condition, students were informed that their answers would be anonymously shared. This may have activated social incentives related to persuasion or altruism - such as a desire to inform or help others. These motives, while distinct from image concerns, may

[13] I check manually because of the small sample size and because I have initial hypotheses about potential factors that I extend to derive a comprehensive categorization. Such a procedure is difficult to standardize. I'll make the answers available upon request.

[14] Bocconi students have access to multiple news outlets, including the New York Times and The Economist.

also increase information demand and merit further investigation as complementary mechanisms.

Finally, I cannot fully exclude social desirability or experimenter demand effects, despite incentivization and anonymity. It is also possible that self-signaling played a role: if students wanted to perceive themselves as informed or conscientious citizens, they may have acquired information to reinforce this self-image (e.g., Bénabou and Tirole, 2016). Such motives are consistent with the broader idea that political knowledge is socially valued - either externally or internally - and lend further support to the relevance of norms in shaping information behavior.

4 Beliefs, audience quality, and the structural interpretation

The reduced-form results show that the Public treatment substantially increases willingness to acquire political news and that this effect is stronger when participants perceive their peers as caring about and able to evaluate political knowledge. To quantify the size of this channel and to connect it more directly to the theoretical framework, I estimate a simple structural model of the MPL choices that interprets the Public–Private variation through the lens of social-image utility.

I start from the four belief items measured for each participant i and topic j: whether other participants (i) care about the topic, (ii) can learn from the article, (iii) can distinguish correct from incorrect answers, and (iv) see being informed as a civic duty. I interpret care, correctness, and civic duty as capturing the strength of political information norms and, via correctness, the audience's ability to evaluate knowledge for that topic. For each topic separately, I standardize these three beliefs to have mean zero and unit variance, and define an "audience norms and evaluative capacity" index as their equal-weighted average. I then re-standardize this index to have mean zero and unit variance across all participant–topic pairs. The resulting measure m_{ij} summarizes individual i's subjective expectations about how strongly the audience demands and can evaluate being informed about topic j. Because I focus on a single focal audience and construct the index from participant i's own beliefs, I write it as m_{ij} - participant i's perceived counterpart of the audience index m_{gj} - and suppress g in what follows.

In each MPL scenario (i, j, l), participant i decides whether to forgo an amount of money p_l to receive the article on topic j. I model the latent utility difference between choosing the article and choosing the money as

$$\Delta U_{ijl} = b_j - \alpha p_l + \beta_{\text{Pub}} \cdot Public_i + \beta_m \cdot m_{ij} + \lambda \cdot Public_i \cdot m_{ij} + \xi_{ijl}, \tag{2}$$

where b_j is the topic-specific private value of the article, $\alpha > 0$ is the marginal utility of money, β_{Pub} captures a baseline Public–Private difference in valuations at $m_{ij} = 0$, β_m captures how valuations vary with m_{ij} in the Private condition, λ measures how the Public effect varies with m_{ij}, m_{ij} is the audience norms and evaluative capacity index, and ξ_{ijl} is an unobserved component capturing all remaining determinants of the choice in scenario (i, j, l). The indicator $Public_i$ equals one in the Public condition, where answers are read aloud to the group, and zero in the Private condition, where answers remain confidential. Under this specification, the term $\lambda \cdot Public_i \cdot m_{ij}$ captures how strongly social-image considerations tied to political information norms and evaluative capacity shift the value of information when answers are observable. Because m_{ij} is not randomized, the estimate of λ should be interpreted as how the Public effect varies with observed beliefs about audience norms and evaluative capacity, under the assumption that - conditional on topic and session fixed effects - there are no unobserved factors that are both correlated with m_{ij} and affect the Public–Private difference in valuations.

Formally, I assume that the conditional probability of choosing the article follows a logit form,

$$\Pr(\text{take}_{ijl} = 1 \mid p_l, Public_i, m_{ij}, \text{topic}_j) = \Lambda\big(b_j - \alpha p_l + \beta_{\text{Pub}} Public_i + \beta_m m_{ij} + \lambda\, Public_i m_{ij}\big),$$

with $\Lambda(\cdot)$ the logistic cdf, and estimate this relationship by pooled logit. The specification includes topic fixed effects, and I compute standard errors clustered at the participant level. Clustering at the participant level makes inference robust to arbitrary correlation and heteroskedasticity of the unobserved component within participants.

Table 4 reports the estimates from two specifications: a baseline model with topic fixed effects only, and a version that additionally includes session fixed effects. Across both, higher prices strongly reduce the probability of taking the article, as expected: a one-euro increase in the price multiplies the odds of choosing the article by about $\exp(-0.56) \approx 0.57$, a reduction of roughly 40%. At the average level of audience norms and evaluative capacity ($m_{ij} = 0$), the Public treatment has a positive and statistically significant effect on article demand: in the baseline specification, the coefficient on Public is 0.43, implying that moving from Private to Public multiplies the odds of choosing the article by about $\exp(0.43) \approx 1.5$, an increase of just over 50%.

By contrast, the main effect of m_{ij} in the Private condition is small and statistically indistinguishable from zero in both columns. That is, perceived audience norms and evaluative capacity do not predict news demand when choices remain confidential. The key term is the interac-

Table 4: Structural logit estimates of article demand

	Dependent variable: Take article	
	(1) Baseline	(2) + Session FE
Price (euros)		
price_eur	-0.555***	-0.585***
	(0.030)	(0.030)
Public condition		
public	0.432**	0.462**
	(0.184)	(0.186)
Audience norms index		
m	0.019	0.041
	(0.114)	(0.124)
Public × audience norms		
public $\times m$	0.353**	0.347**
	(0.166)	(0.167)
Topic fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Session fixed effects	No	Yes
Derived quantities (euros)		
α (abs. price slope)	0.555	0.585
λ (per 1 s.d. m)	0.636	0.594
Public–Private gap at $m = -1$ s.d.	0.144	0.196
Public–Private gap at $m = 0$ s.d.	0.780	0.790
Public–Private gap at $m = 1$ s.d.	1.416	1.384
Observations	6,400	6,400
Participants	320	320

Note: Standard errors, clustered at the participant level, in parentheses. *p< 0.1; **p< 0.05; ***p< 0.01.

tion $Public_i \cdot m_{ij}$, which is positive and statistically significant in all specifications (around 0.35, $p \approx 0.03$). This indicates that the effect of making choices public is substantially stronger when participants perceive the audience as more normatively demanding and better able to evaluate political knowledge.

To interpret the magnitude of this amplification, I convert the logit coefficients into euros. Let $\hat{\alpha}$ denote the estimated absolute value of the price coefficient and $\hat{\lambda}$ the estimated coefficient on $Public_i \cdot m_{ij}$. The ratio $\hat{\lambda}/\hat{\alpha}$ gives the additional willingness-to-accept, in euros, generated by social-image concerns when the audience is one standard deviation above, rather than at, the average level of perceived norms and evaluative capacity. Across specifications - with and without session fixed effects, and with beliefs standardized within topic or globally - this social-image premium lies between about 0.58 and 0.64 euros per standard deviation of m_{ij}. In the baseline specification, moving from an average audience ($m_{ij} = 0$) to an audience one standard deviation above average in perceived norms and evaluative capacity ($m_{ij} = 1$) increases the social-image component of the article's value by about 0.64 euros.

It is also instructive to compare the implied Public–Private gap in the value of the article at different levels of m_{ij}. In the baseline specification, the corresponding "WTP-equivalent" difference between Public and Private is approximately 0.14 euros when the audience is one standard deviation below average in perceived norms and evaluative capacity ($m_{ij} = -1$), about 0.78 euros at the average level ($m_{ij} = 0$), and roughly 1.42 euros when the audience is one standard deviation above average ($m_{ij} = 1$). Thus, when participants perceive their peers as relatively indifferent and unable to judge political knowledge, social-image incentives to acquire news are essentially negligible. When they perceive the audience as engaged, demanding, and evaluative, social-image considerations alone add well over one euro to the value of reading the article. This stark asymmetry underscores the role of political information norms as a multiplier of social-image motives.

Figure 2 visualizes these patterns by plotting the model's predicted probability of choosing the article as a function of the price, separately for the Public and Private conditions and for low and high values of the audience norms index. When norms are low ($m_{ij} = -1$), the Public and Private demand curves are almost indistinguishable across the entire price range. When norms are high ($m_{ij} = 1$), the Public curve lies clearly above the Private curve at all prices, with substantial gaps at intermediate prices. Together, Table 4 and Figure 2 show that political information norms and evaluative capacity have little effect on information demand in low-norm environments, but in high-norm environments they make social-image incentives quantitatively important.

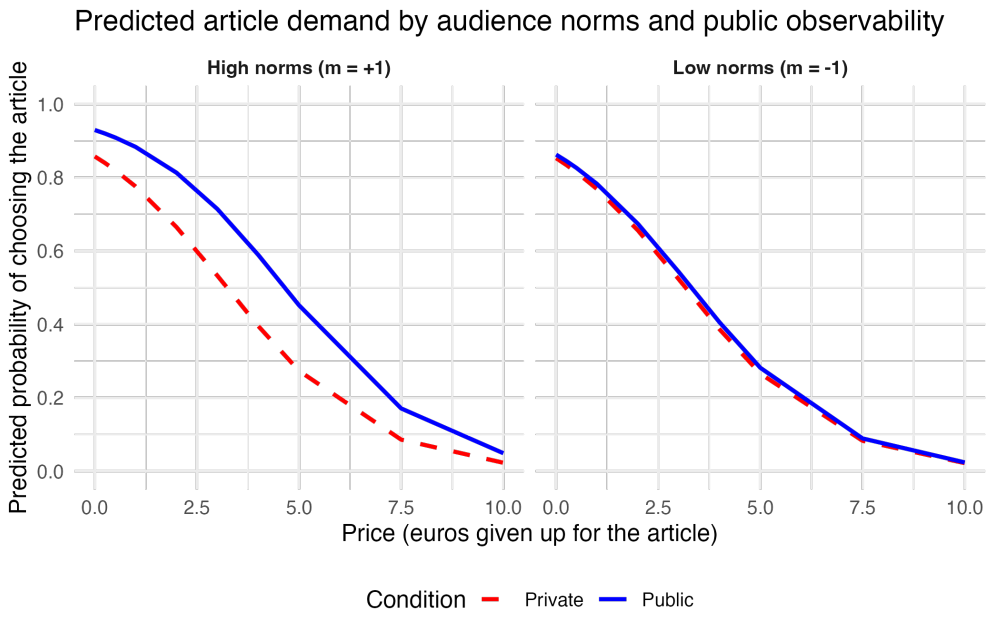


Figure 2: Predicted probability of choosing the article by price, audience norms, and public observability. Note: The figure plots predicted probabilities from the baseline structural logit model for low ($m = -1$) and high ($m = 1$) audience norms, separately for the Public (blue solid) and Private (red dashed) conditions.

5 Survey Evidence on Political Information Norms

This section provides descriptive evidence suggesting that political information is socially valued and that social norms around being informed may be widespread. These norms, in turn, form the basis for social image concerns, which my framework and experiment treat as potential drivers of political information acquisition.

Survey data from 19 countries (Pew, 2022) show that a median of 46% of respondents view following politics in their home country as "very important" for being a good member of society, and 86% say it is at least "somewhat important." Similarly, 43% (very important) and 88% (at least somewhat important) say the same about following international affairs. In Japan, respondents ranked being informed about domestic politics as more important than voting or acting on climate change. U.S. data from the General Social Survey suggest these norms are not new: over 90% of respondents say it is at least somewhat important to stay informed about public issues, and more than half consider it "very important" (GSS, 1984). In short, across contexts, political information appears to be seen as a civic obligation - consistent with the existence of norms that can trigger social image concerns.

The next two subsections explore this further. First, I test for associations between social interaction and political information acquisition using World Values Survey data from 64 countries. Second, I examine how socioeconomic variation in perceived norms, using Pew survey data, may relate to well-documented inequalities in political knowledge (Angelucci and Prat, 2024). These patterns suggest that social image concerns may not only shape political learning but also contribute to the amplification of information inequalities across groups.

5.1 Information Norms

The model in Section 1 predicts that anticipated social interaction can increase political information acquisition through social image concerns, rooted in perceived norms. To test the external relevance of this mechanism, I draw on representative survey data from 64 countries in Round 7 of the World Values Survey (2017–2021).

As an imperfect but plausible proxy for political information acquisition, I use the frequency with which respondents report getting informed about "what is going on in this country and the world" via newspapers, TV, radio, or the internet. The key independent variable is how often respondents report discussing politics with friends. According to the framework, such interactions, when anticipated, can increase information demand by making political knowledge socially valuable.

Estimating this relationship in observational data is challenging. Political interest may drive both information acquisition and the desire to discuss politics. Alternatively, individuals may engage in political discussions to persuade others, to inform them (altruistically), or because of shared social environments shaped by homophily. These factors can confound the link between discussion and information-seeking.

While the survey setting does not permit causal identification, I adjust for plausible confounders. Specifically, I control for:

- political interest (elicited directly),
- political action (an index based on participation in activities such as protests, petitions, or political donations),
- voting behavior in local and national elections,
- the perceived importance of fair elections,

- and socioeconomic characteristics (captured via fixed effects for country-sex, education, and occupation groups).[15]

I also include interaction terms between discussion frequency and political interest or action to account for alternative motives like persuasion or prosocial behavior.

Using a linear probability model, I find that respondents who discuss politics with friends at least occasionally are significantly more likely to consume political information daily (by 3.4 percentage points) or at least weekly (by 2.9 percentage points), compared to those who do not (both $p < 0.001$). These effects are economically meaningful, comparable in size to the effects of political interest or action. Results are robust to using a continuous (standardized) measure of political discussion (see Table 18) and are visualized in Figure 3 as a binned scatterplot using residualized variables.[16]

In sum, while not causal, these results provide evidence consistent with Prediction 1 from the theoretical model: anticipated social interaction is positively associated with political information acquisition. Given the size of the effect, its robustness, and the scale of the dataset, nearly 80,000 individuals across 64 countries, the findings support the validity of the social image channel as a driver of political learning across diverse contexts.

5.2 Information Inequality

Angelucci and Prat (2024) demonstrate that access to political and news-related information is unevenly distributed among the US population, favoring older, college-educated, male, and higher-income individuals, who are 18 percentage points more likely to discern true news stories compared to their counterparts. Drawing from an international Pew sample run in 18 countries, I show that these demographic characteristics (except for ethnicity) also predict a 13-15 percentage point higher likelihood of considering it very important for a good citizen to stay informed about current events (column 1 in table 6). This correlation not only suggests that perceptions of social norms are associated with information acquisition but also underscores that perceptions of social norms, and thus, image concerns, may relate to inequalities in information access. A similar relationship

[15]The following is my regression equation.

$$y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 DiscussOccasionally_i + \beta_2 PoliticalInterest_i + \beta_3 PoliticalAction_i + \tag{3}$$
$$\beta_4 Voting_i + \beta_6 ImportanceElection_i + \delta X_{SC,E,O} + \varepsilon_i \tag{4}$$

where y_i is the outcome of interest, $X_{SC,E,O}$ captures the fixed effects, $DiscussOccasionally_i = 1$ if i discusses politics at least occasionally with friends, and all other variables are standardized.

[16]Residuals from a model including all covariates except the discussion variable are used, plotted in 30 bins.

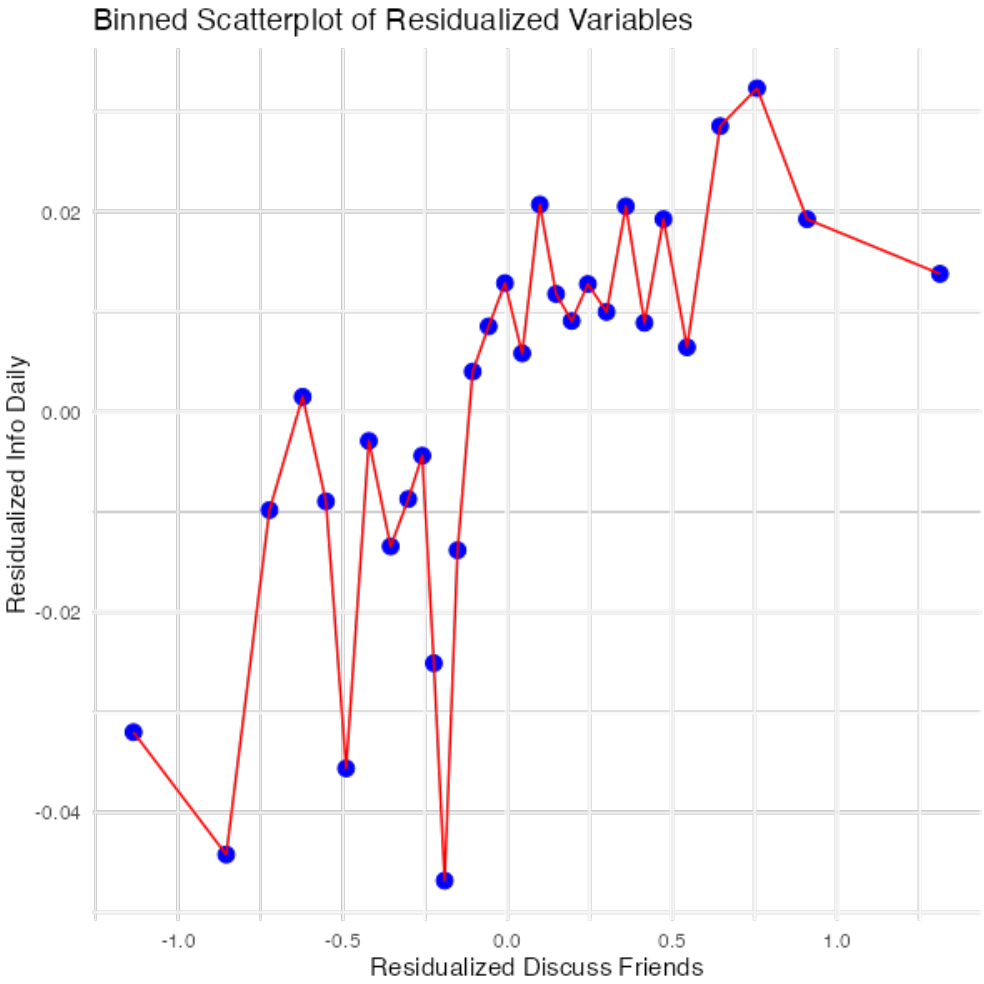


Figure 3: Binned Scatterplot of Residualized Variables

Table 5: Regression Results with Robust Standard Errors

	Dependent variable:	
	Info Daily	Info Weekly
	(1)	(2)
Discuss occasionally	0.034***	0.029***
	(0.004)	(0.002)
Political interest	0.017***	0.018***
	(0.003)	(0.002)
Political action	0.045***	0.037***
	(0.003)	(0.002)
Voting	0.042***	0.021***
	(0.002)	(0.001)
Importance elections	0.020***	0.008***
	(0.001)	(0.001)
Discuss occasionally	0.010**	−0.005
x Political interest	(0.003)	(0.003)
Discuss occasionally	−0.028***	−0.029***
x Political action	(0.003)	(0.002)
Sex x Country SE	Yes	Yes
Education FE	Yes	Yes
Occupation FE	Yes	Yes
Robust SE	Yes	Yes
Observations	78,733	78,733
R^2	0.090	0.072
Adjusted R^2	0.089	0.070
Residual Std. Error (df = 78635)	0.356	0.237

*p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001

Info Daily is a dummy that takes a value of 1 if the respondent states to learn daily about what is going on in this country and the world from daily newspapers, TV news, Radio news, or the internet. Info weekly is equivalently defined for at least weekly consumption. Discuss occasionally is equal to 1 if the respondent discussed political matters at least occasionally. Political action (Q209-Q216), voting (Q221-Q222), and the importance of fair elections (Q234) are standardized measures obtained from multiple WVS questions.

is observed for information about international events (column 2 in table 6).

While these associations do not establish causation, they support the following interpretations. They indicate that social norms and concerns about one's image may contribute to the systematic disparities in levels of information. This could be because certain individuals are more knowledgeable due to their adherence to perceived social norms. Alternatively, within homophilic networks, individuals similar to each other may experience increased social pressure to stay informed because i) their environment holds stronger expectations and norms regarding information awareness, and ii) is itself informed, allowing for assessments of others' awareness levels. In both cases, norms and image concerns may act as mechanisms that amplify pre-existing inequalities in political learning and voice.

Table 6: Fixed Effects Models

	Dependent variable:	
	FollowNatPol	CurrIntlEvents
	(1)	(2)
Age > 49	0.076***	0.042**
	(0.018)	(0.017)
College	0.052***	0.052***
	(0.008)	(0.010)
Income ≥ Country median	0.025**	0.026***
	(0.011)	(0.006)
Male	−0.024	−0.042***
	(0.016)	(0.014)
Country FE	Yes	Yes
Clustered SE	Country	Country
Observations	16,227	16,227
R^2	0.053	0.054
Adjusted R^2	0.052	0.053
Note:	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01	

FollowNatPol is a variable that takes a value of 1 if the respondent finds it very important for a good citizen to follow national politics. CurrIntlEvents is the corresponding variable for current events in other countries. All data is obtained from Pew 2022.

6 Conclusion and Outlook

This paper shows that social norms can increase demand for political information through social image concerns. I develop a theoretical framework in which individuals anticipate that being informed signals desirable traits to others. A laboratory experiment provides causal evidence that exposure to an audience increases willingness to acquire political information, and survey data from 64 countries suggest that such mechanisms may operate across diverse social and institutional contexts. Additional cross-national evidence indicates that norms around being informed vary systematically across socioeconomic groups, potentially contributing to persistent inequalities in political knowledge.

These findings have several broader implications. First, they suggest that political information acquisition is not merely a private decision but is shaped by social forces, especially norms and peer expectations. Second, the interaction effects hypothesized and partially supported here call for further investigation: social learning, persuasion, altruism, and even misinformation may all interact with image concerns to shape what citizens learn. Third, the results open new avenues for understanding inequality in political knowledge and voice: norms and image concerns may reinforce barriers to participation and representation for disadvantaged groups.

Future research should examine how social incentives evolve in polarized environments, whether they can be shaped through policy or institutional design, and how they interact with broader dynamics of expression, misinformation, and civic engagement. Understanding these forces is crucial in a political landscape where attention is scarce, misinformation is widespread, and democratic participation depends on who chooses to learn and what they choose to know.

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A Appendix - Model

Setup I consider a continuum of individuals, each with a type $\theta \in \{H, L\}$, $\Pr(\theta = H) = \pi \in (0,1)$, and an image-concern intensity $\lambda_i \geq 0$ drawn from a truncated normal distribution with cdf F on support $[a, b]$ (the normal specification of image concerns is standard; e.g., Bénabou and Tirole, 2006). Each individual chooses whether to acquire information, $e \in \{0, 1\}$.[17] The type governs the intrinsic net benefit of acquiring information,

$$b(1, H) = h > 0, \qquad b(1, L) = l < 0, \qquad b(0, \cdot) = 0,$$

so that acquiring information is intrinsically worthwhile for the high type but not for the low type. In addition, the audience attaches normative value $w > 0$ to the high type, and individuals care about the image they project (Bursztyn and Jensen, 2017): meeting ν peers, individual i derives social-image utility $\nu\lambda_i w\, E_i\big[\Pr_j(\theta_i = H) \mid e_i\big]$ from the belief a peer j holds about i's type. The ex-ante utility is

$$V_i(\theta_i, e_i) = b(e_i, \theta_i) + \nu\lambda_i w\, E_i\big[\Pr_j(\theta_i = H) \mid e_i\big].$$

Because $h > 0$ and acquiring information only raises image, the high type always acquires information ($e_H = 1$); I therefore focus on the low type.

Evaluation technology I assume that when i is matched with a peer, the peer can judge whether i is informed only if the peer is *herself* informed about the topic. A randomly matched peer is informed with probability equal to the population informed share,

$$S \;=\; \pi + (1-\pi)\big(1 - F(\lambda^*)\big),$$

[17] Here e denotes information-acquisition effort - the appendix analogue of the acquisition decision d in Section 1. It is distinct from the audience's evaluative capacity e_{gj} of the framework, which is endogenized below through the informed share.

where λ^* is the image-concern threshold above which low types acquire information (derived below). An informed peer perfectly observes whether i is informed; an uninformed peer learns nothing about i. The probability that i is evaluated is therefore the informed share S itself - an *availability* that rises endogenously with the share of others who choose to become informed.

Reputation The audience values the type $\theta = H$, and being informed is evidence of it (the high type always acquires information; low types do so only when image concerns are strong). By Bayes' rule, a peer who evaluates i and observes that i is informed holds posterior

$$R_1 \;=\; \Pr(\theta = H \mid \text{informed}) \;=\; \frac{\pi}{S},$$

because the informed population consists of all high types (mass π) and the informed low types (mass $(1-\pi)(1-F(\lambda^*))$), which together sum to S. A peer who observes that i is uninformed holds $R_0 = \Pr(\theta = H \mid \text{uninformed}) = 0$, since no high type is uninformed. A peer who cannot evaluate i (an uninformed peer, probability $1-S$) does not update and holds the prior π. The expected reputation of an individual, by their own acquisition choice, is therefore

$$E_i\big[\Pr_j(\theta_i = H) \mid e_i = 1\big] = S \cdot \tfrac{\pi}{S} + (1-S)\,\pi = \pi(2-S),$$
$$E_i\big[\Pr_j(\theta_i = H) \mid e_i = 0\big] = S \cdot 0 + (1-S)\,\pi = (1-S)\,\pi.$$

These average to the prior π across the population, as required by the law of iterated expectations.

Equilibrium A low type acquires information whenever the image gain covers the intrinsic cost, $l + \nu\lambda_i w\big(E_i[\cdot \mid e_i = 1] - E_i[\cdot \mid e_i = 0]\big) \geq 0$. The reputational gain from being informed is

$$E_i[\cdot \mid e_i = 1] - E_i[\cdot \mid e_i = 0] = \pi(2-S) - (1-S)\,\pi = \pi,$$

so the availability share S cancels. The indifferent low type $\{L, \lambda^*\}$ therefore satisfies $l + \nu\lambda^* w\pi = 0$, i.e.

$$\boxed{\lambda^* = -\frac{l}{\nu\, w\, \pi}}$$

An interior equilibrium - some but not all low types informed - obtains when $a < \lambda^* < b$. Because λ^* does not depend on S, the informed share follows residually as $S = \pi + (1-\pi)\big(1 - F(-l/\nu w\pi)\big)$, and the equilibrium is unique.

What amplifies, and what does not The endogenous *availability* of evaluators washes out of the incentive: as more individuals become informed, being informed is less distinctive of the high type, so the premium $R_1 = \pi/S$ *falls* (congestion), while the chance of meeting a competent evaluator, S, *rises*, and the two exactly offset ($S \cdot R_1 = \pi$). What does *not* wash out is the audience's *normative valuation* w: it scales the image gain directly, so a more demanding audience raises the marginal return to being informed and lowers λ^* - the equilibrium counterpart of the paper's finding that observability matters more when the audience is perceived as caring about political knowledge. Crucially, this cancellation is a feature of rewarding an *inference about type*: because being informed signals a type, it dilutes as it spreads, and availability merely offsets that dilution. Were people instead to value the *action* per se - being informed for its own sake, independent of what it signals - no such dilution would arise, and the model could generate complementarity, a social multiplier, and tipping. Such action-based rewards (conversational or participation value, or a norm whose esteem strengthens with adherence, $w = w(S)$) lie outside the type-signaling channel I isolate here and are a natural direction for future work.[18]

Comparative statics The informed share $S = \pi + (1-\pi)\big(1 - F(-l/\nu w\pi)\big)$ increases in each primitive of the social environment:

- the audience's normative valuation w (a more demanding audience lowers λ^*) - the model's counterpart of the framework's index m;
- the intrinsic net benefit of the low type l (a less negative l lowers λ^*);
- the number of social encounters ν (more exposure lowers λ^*);
- the share of high types π (directly, through more high types, and indirectly, by lowering λ^*);
- the mean image concern $\bar{\lambda}$ (a rightward shift of F lowers $F(\lambda^*)$).

Each comparative static maps a dimension of the social environment - how rewarding, how observed, how discerning, and how norm-laden it is - into the equilibrium share of informed individuals (Figure 4), the channel through which heterogeneous environments translate into unequal knowledge.

Relation to the framework This appendix microfounds the reduced-form image payoff of Section 1. The norm-weight component of the framework's index $m = f(w_{gj}, e_{gj})$ maps to the audience's normative valuation w, which scales the equilibrium image premium $w\pi$; its evaluative-capacity component maps to the availability of competent evaluators S, which in this type-signaling

[18] The offsetting of congestion and availability makes the equilibrium unique.

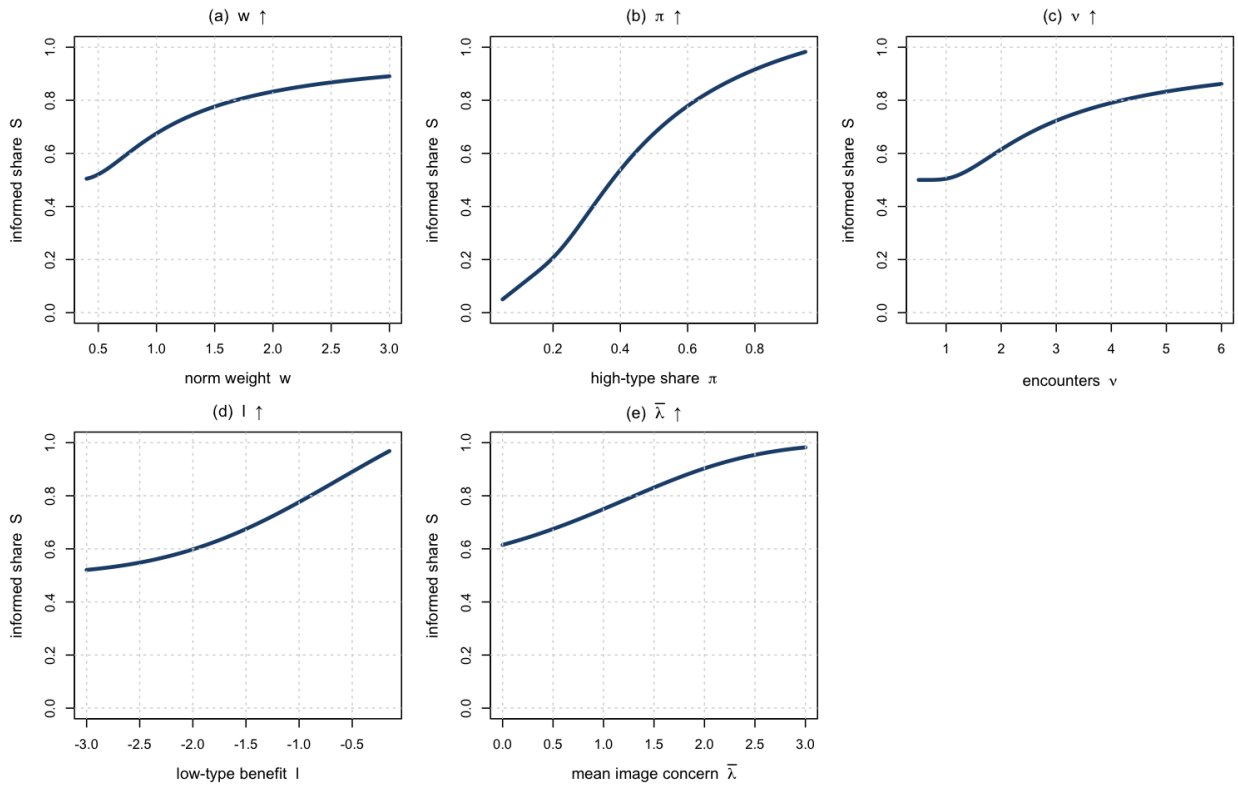


Figure 4: Comparative statics of the equilibrium informed share $S = \pi + (1-\pi)\big(1 - F(-l/\nu w\pi)\big)$. Each panel varies one primitive, holding the others at the baseline $l = -1.5$, $\nu = 2.5$, $\pi = 0.5$, $w = 1$, $\bar{\lambda} = 0.5$, $\sigma = 1$, and support $[a, b] = [0, 5]$. The informed share rises with the audience's normative valuation w (a) - the model's counterpart of the framework's index m - and with the high-type share π (b), social encounters ν (c), the low-type net benefit l (d), and the mean image concern $\bar{\lambda}$ (e).

benchmark offsets congestion rather than amplifying. The social-image term $\lambda \cdot Public \cdot m$ in (1) thus corresponds to $\nu\lambda\, w\pi$: observability (*Public*) activates evaluation, and w scales its strength. In the empirical implementation m_{ij} is centered and standardized, so the baseline *Public* coefficient captures the image payoff at the average perceived audience while the interaction coefficient captures how it varies with m.

Expectations and exposure The *Public* treatment raises a subject's exposure, and the effect of this extra exposure depends on the subject's *expectations* about the audience. Writing $\hat{e}$ for the perceived probability of being competently evaluated and $\hat{S}$ for the perceived informed pool, a subject expects an image gain $\hat{e}\,\pi/\hat{S}$ from acquiring information, so the return to exposure rises with the perceived evaluative capacity $\hat{e}$. The benchmark cancellation is the rational-expectations knife-edge $\hat{e} = \hat{S}$; because the experiment measures and varies these perceptions directly - through the correctness beliefs in m - rather than imposing that tie, evaluative capacity amplifies the exposure effect out of equilibrium.

B Appendix - Experiment

Set 1 The first set of articles and questions consists of the following two articles and the corresponding questions. Students knew the topics (Israel-Hamas conflict, Russia-Ukraine conflict), but neither the content of the articles nor the questions when facing the MPL.

[...] 'From the River to the Sea' Inflames Debate

[. . .] The decades-old phrase has a complicated back story that has led to radically different interpretations by Israelis and Palestinians, and by Americans who support them.

"The reason why this term is so hotly disputed is because it means different things to different people," said Dov Waxman, a professor of Israel studies at the University of California in Los Angeles, adding that "the conflicting interpretations have kind of grown over time."

The phrase "from the river to the sea" - or in Arabic, "min al-nahr ila al-bahr" - dates to the dawn of the Palestinian nationalist movement in the early 1960s, about a quarter century before Hamas came into existence. It gained popularity within the Palestine Liberation Organization, or P.L.O., as a call for returning to the borders under British control of Palestine, where Jews and Arabs had both lived before the creation of Israel as a Jewish state in 1948.

The slogan reflects the geography of that original claim: Israel spans the narrow stretch of

land between the Jordan River and the Mediterranean Sea. But the phrase's popularity persisted even as territorial claims shifted, after the P.L.O. entered peace negotiations in the 1990s, formally recognizing Israel's right to exist and coming to governance through the creation of the Palestinian Authority. [...]

https://www.nytimes.com/2023/11/09/us/politics/river-to-the-sea-israel-gaza- palestinians.html

Which river and which sea does the phrase "From the river to the sea" refer to?

War in Ukraine: The Roots of the Crisis

[...] After the Soviet Union collapsed in the early 1990s, NATO expanded eastward, eventually taking in most of the European nations that had been in the Communist sphere.

The Baltic republics of Lithuania, Latvia and Estonia, once parts of the Soviet Union, joined the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, as did Poland, Romania and others. That put NATO forces hundreds of miles closer to Moscow, directly bordering Russia. Then in 2008, NATO leaders said they planned - some day - to enroll Ukraine, though that is still seen as a far-off prospect. [...]

In December 2021, months before invading, Russia presented NATO and the United States with a set of written demands that it said were needed to ensure its security [...]. Foremost among them were a guarantee that Ukraine never join NATO, and that NATO draw down its forces in the Eastern European countries that had already joined. [...]

East-West relations worsened drastically in early 2014, when mass protests in Ukraine forced out a president closely allied with Mr. Putin. Russia swiftly invaded and annexed Crimea, a part of Ukraine with enormous strategic importance. Moscow also fomented, armed and reinforced a separatist rebellion that took control of part of the Donbas region of Ukraine in a war that had killed more than 13,000 people before the invasion last year. [...]

https://www.nytimes.com/article/russia-ukraine-nato-europe.html

Which part of Ukraine did Russia invade in 2014?

Set 2 The second set of articles and questions consists of the following two articles and the corresponding questions.

What Does It Mean to Recognize a Palestinian State?

The decision by three European countries - Ireland, Norway and Spain - to recognize a Pales-

tinian state fits into a long-term goal of Palestinian leaders to secure diplomatic acceptance, but it appears that the immediate practical impact will be limited.

Broadly speaking, recognizing a state means declaring that it meets the conditions of statehood under international law. It typically opens a path to setting up diplomatic relations and an embassy there. But the European countries appeared to be mostly concerned with expressing support for Palestinians and sending a message to Israel at a time of deepening international concern about its conduct of the war. [...]

To date, around 140 countries, mainly outside Western Europe, have recognized a Palestinian state, according to the Palestinian Authority's website. These do not include the United States, Israel's most significant ally, or Britain, France or Germany. [...]

The United Nations voted in 1947 to create an independent Arab state alongside a Jewish one, but the plan was rejected by neighboring Arab governments and Palestinian Arabs, and the state of Israel was founded amid a war the following year. In the decades since, plans for a two-state solution have repeatedly been stymied. [...]

https://www.nytimes.com/2024/05/22/world/middleeast/palestinian-state.html

Which European countries recognize a Palestinian state?

War in Ukraine

[...] Seeking to punish Moscow for the invasion, Western nations imposed heavy economic sanctions, including on oligarchs close to Mr. Putin. Mr. Biden vowed to turn Mr. Putin into a "pariah."

U.S. and European financial penalties and restrictions also throttled banks and other businesses in Russia, limiting the Russian government's ability to use its enormous foreign currency reserves and impeding millions of Russians from using their credit cards, accessing their bank deposits or traveling abroad. Additionally, European countries placed an embargo on Russian oil and sharply cut gas imports, trying to slash Moscow's cash flow.

The sanctions have damaged the Russian economy but have fallen far short of bringing Moscow to its knees, in part because the Kremlin has strengthened its trade and financial ties with other economic partners, especially China, Turkey and India. [...]

Europe has important trade ties with Russia, and stands to lose far more than the United States from sanctions. It was long dependent on Russian gas supplies, a weakness that Mr. Putin

immediately sought to exploit, but in the past year European countries have shifted to other energy sources with remarkable speed. [...]

https://www.nytimes.com/article/russia-ukraine-nato-europe.html

Which large countries strengthened their trade and financial ties with Russia after the beginning of the Russia-Ukraine war?

C Appendix - Results

Table 7: Wilcoxon rank-sum tests

Data	Test	Public (n, median, IQR)	Private (n, median, IQR)	W	p-value
data_consistent	One-sided	164, 7, 3 - 12.5	156, 5, 1.5 - 9.1875	14527	0.02
	Two-sided				0.04

Table 8: Welch t-tests

Data	Test	Public (n, mean, sd)	Private (n, mean, sd)	t	df		p-value
data_consistent	One-sided	164, 7.95, 5.88	156, 6.59, 5.57	-2.13	318	0.02	
	Two-sided					0.03	

Table 9: Shapiro-Wilkins tests

Data	Sample	n	W	p-value
data_consistent	Pooled	320	0.91	0.00
	Public	164	0.93	0.00
	Private	156	0.90	0.00

Table 10: Regression Results with Gender and Session FE

	Dependent variable:			
	WTP			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Treat	0.722^{**}	0.776^{**}	1.226^{***}	1.293^{***}
	(0.319)	(0.322)	(0.341)	(0.344)
High	0.029	0.021	0.083	0.075
	(0.120)	(0.120)	(0.133)	(0.133)
Male	-1.100^{***}	-1.094^{***}	-1.165^{***}	-1.161^{***}
	(0.311)	(0.315)	(0.346)	(0.350)
Treat:High	0.112	0.121	0.051	0.073
	(0.166)	(0.166)	(0.190)	(0.189)
Topic FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Clustered SE	ID	ID	ID	ID
Observations	640	626	536	524
R^2	0.148	0.152	0.205	0.213
Adjusted R^2	0.103	0.107	0.154	0.164
Note:				*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 11: Regression Results with Session Fixed Effects and Robust Standard Errors

	Dependent variable:			
	IH-Article	RU-Article	IH-Article	RU-Article
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
WTP-IH	0.055***			
	(0.008)			
WTP-RU		0.049***		
		(0.007)		
Treat			0.012	0.024
			(0.045)	(0.043)
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Robust SE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	320	320	320	320
R^2	0.246	0.221	0.085	0.078
Adjusted R^2	0.173	0.146	-0.003	-0.011
Note:				*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 12: Regression Results

	Dependent variable:
	Timing NYT Page Submit
Treat	2.557
	(4.396)
Topic x Set FE	Yes
WTP FE	Yes
Clustered SE	ID
Observations	533
R^2	0.100
Adjusted R^2	0.074
Note:	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 13: Regression Results

	Dependent variable:			
	Aud_Correct_Std	Aud_Learn_Std	Aud_Care_Std	Aud_Duty_Std
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
High	0.118*	0.018	0.062	0.026
	(0.065)	(0.055)	(0.062)	(0.054)
Topic FE	Yes	Yes		
Topic:Set FE			Yes	Yes
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Clustered SE	ID	ID	ID	ID
Observations	626	626	626	626
R^2	0.077	0.084	0.069	0.075
Adjusted R^2	0.034	0.041	0.024	0.030
Note:				*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 14: Regression Results (Part 1)

	Dependent variable:			
	WTP			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Aud_Correct_Std	0.119			
	(0.133)			
Aud_Learn_Std		0.276*		
		(0.153)		
Aud_Care_Std			0.221*	
			(0.126)	
Aud_Duty_Std				0.202
				(0.155)
Topic FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Clustered SE	ID	ID	ID	ID
Observations	626	626	626	626
R^2	0.003	0.010	0.007	0.006
Adjusted R^2	−0.0001	0.007	0.004	0.003
Note:		*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01		

Table 15: Regression Results (Part 2)

	Dependent variable:			
	WTP			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Treat	0.733**	0.808**	0.775**	0.801**
	(0.326)	(0.321)	(0.321)	(0.322)
Aud_Correct_Std	−0.002			
	(0.177)			
Aud_Correct_Std:Treat	0.191			
	(0.255)			
Aud_Learn_Std		0.307		
		(0.196)		
Aud_Learn_Std:Treat		0.002		
		(0.298)		
Aud_Care_Std			0.039	
			(0.171)	
Aud_Care_Std:Treat			0.397	
			(0.243)	
Aud_Duty_Std				0.103
				(0.208)
Aud_Duty_Std:Treat				0.271
				(0.306)
Topic FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Clustered SE	ID	ID	ID	ID
Observations	626	626	626	626
R^2	0.020	0.029	0.029	0.027
Adjusted R^2	0.014	0.022	0.023	0.021
Residual Std. Error (df = 621)	2.955	2.942	2.941	2.945
Note:				*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 16: Regression Results (Part 1) - with Gender & Session FE

	Dependent variable:			
	WTP			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Aud_Correct_Std	0.030			
	(0.129)			
Aud_Learn_Std		0.302**		
		(0.144)		
Aud_Care_Std			0.195	
			(0.125)	
Aud_Duty_Std				0.112
				(0.150)
Topic FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Gender FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Clustered SE	ID	ID	ID	ID
Observations	626	626	626	626
R^2	0.132	0.142	0.136	0.133
Adjusted R^2	0.090	0.100	0.094	0.091
Note:		*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01		

Table 17: Regression Results (Part 2) - with Gender & Session FE

	Dependent variable:			
	WTP			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Treat	0.826***	0.883***	0.860***	0.861***
	(0.310)	(0.306)	(0.306)	(0.309)
Aud_Correct_Std	−0.092			
	(0.181)			
Aud_Correct_Std:Treat	0.180			
	(0.262)			
Aud_Learn_Std		0.320*		
		(0.193)		
Aud_Learn_Std:Treat		0.025		
		(0.283)		
Aud_Care_Std			0.018	
			(0.176)	
Aud_Care_Std:Treat			0.404*	
			(0.242)	
Aud_Duty_Std				0.074
				(0.214)
Aud_Duty_Std:Treat				0.152
				(0.292)
Topic FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Gender FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Clustered SE	ID	ID	ID	ID
Observations	626	626	626	626
R^2	0.152	0.163	0.161	0.155
Adjusted R^2	0.108	0.120	0.117	0.110
Note:				*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 18: Regression Results with Robust Standard Errors

	Dependent variable:	
	Info Daily	Info Weekly
	(1)	(2)
Discuss friends	0.018***	0.013***
	(0.002)	(0.001)
Political interest	0.023***	0.016***
	(0.002)	(0.001)
Political action	0.025***	0.018***
	(0.002)	(0.001)
Voting	0.042***	0.021***
	(0.002)	(0.001)
importance elections	0.020***	0.008***
	(0.001)	(0.001)
Discuss friends	0.003*	−0.003***
x Political interest	(0.001)	(0.001)
Discuss friends	−0.010***	−0.011***
x Political action	(0.001)	(0.001)
Sex x Country SE	Y	Y
Education FE	Y	Y
Occupation FE	Y	Y
Robust SE	Y	Y
Observations	78,733	78,733
R^2	0.090	0.069
Adjusted R^2	0.088	0.068
Residual Std. Error (df = 78635)	0.356	0.237
Note:	*p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001	

Info Daily is a dummy that takes a value of 1 if the respondent states to learn daily about what is going on in this country and the world from daily newspapers, TV news, Radio news, or the internet. Info weekly is equivalently defined for at least weekly consumption. Discuss friends is a standardized measure of the frequency at which the respondent discusses political matters with friends. Political action (Q209-Q216), voting (Q221-Q222), and the importance of fair elections (Q234) are standardized measures obtained from multiple WVS questions.